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David Weiss

David Weiss is a highly respected trumpeter and composer in the New York City jazz scene. He is the music director of the New Jazz Composers Octet, Points of Departure, and the Cookers.

David was interviewed via Zoom on February 3, 2022 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe for the Fillius Jazz Archive at Hamilton College. I'm very pleased to have David Weiss with me today who is a composer, arranger, band leader, and, according to *Jazz Times* has righteous trumpet chops.

DW: Okay.

MR: That goes back a ways, a review.

DW: Maybe they're not so righteous anymore.

MR: Well I'm just — I'm wondering if you're able to keep your trumpet chops up during this almost two years of Covid now?

DW: It's been interesting. It's been interesting. Yes and no. I mean it's been two years and there's been a lot of up and downs and there's been things in my personal life that I let take everything over because — I suppose they do — my mother passed away a little over two years ago, the house we grew up in in Queens is a big houses and it took months and months to clean it out. So, with no gigs, I let that other stuff take over, you know, the last few months. But other times I went away for a while and was able to practice more than I had practiced in years. Right after that low point of not playing at all for the first time in my life for like three or four months I think it was. Then I was able to go somewhere and basically have a place to play all the time and practice more than I had for several weeks.

MR: Excuse me, what do you tend to practice?

DW: It's an interesting thing. This is what me and actually the other guys in Cookers were talking about at the beginning of the pandemic. When you're playing a lot, ideally, with trumpet you're basically trying to do maintenance. You know, like an athlete you know. You still, you know you still go to the gym, you still do weight training, whatever it is to keep you in the best shape you can be to do this thing. So that includes physical stuff and, I mean trumpet stuff is kind of calisthenicy. I mean you do a lot of long tones, do a lot of slurs, you do a lot of things just to kind of maintain whatever it is you've achieved at that point. And the thing about the pandemic was okay, you know we all had that like, oh wow, now well at least we'll have this time to, you know, it's not exactly a desert island or a cabin in the woods, but you have suddenly, like wow, this is going to be great. And I have all the time in the world to practice. But what we found after like — those guys

longer than me — but you know me for a considerable amount of time too, we found like oh wow, we can go past maintenance. You know we can actually start working on our craft again, like improving. And it took a minute to be like oh yeah, how did we do that you know. So I went back to basics. I started transcribing solos again, I started expanding the calisthenics and stuff that would probably either try and like improve my range or, you know, make me more consistent. So I was able to work out, you know, instead of like the one hour to keep your chops together, to two hours you know and kind of strengthen a little more, to three or four hours like you know let's go for something that will actually make you, you know, exceed what you've done so far.

MR: When you finally got back together with any of your ensembles, did you notice a positive difference with most of your fellow musicians because of what you're describing?

DW: I don't have the full gamut yet because I haven't, I really haven't gotten together with anybody but the Cookers. One thing Covid has done is the casual get together I guess, I mean why have a jam session if you've got to put people at risk? So I mean I've always been a bit of a hermit so I've stayed in. I haven't done anything with any other bands but the Cookers so I could only relate to them. And that was an interesting phenomenon. You're talking about guys that have gone like at a breakneck pace for fifty years, that suddenly had to stop. They'd be like okay what am I doing? And when we got back together we were a little sloppy but nobody lost anything. I mean you know you wouldn't think — I think the first time we got together — when did this all really start — so we were on tour in March of 2020. I mean February of 2020. And we finished like March 1st. And then less than two weeks later we were about to do a long European tour, like two or three weeks or maybe not that long. A couple of guys already had gigs over there and had gone to Europe, and then it was a big thing when things shut down to get them back home from Europe. We all stayed in touch, you know, and had those conversations like well what are you doing, but by that summer, by July, you know, that first crazy wave in New York was dying down, things were opening up a little bit, it was possible to do things. And I don't know if it was something I sensed or maybe something in me, but it seemed like we needed to get together. Everybody just needed to do something, get back on track and play some music. On that tour in March of 2020 we were going to do a live album. We were preparing to do a live album, and probably record it in London. So we had a label that wanted to do a record and I just said look I'm going to try to do this when we control the situation, you know. We went to Rudy Van Gelder's (a) because it's a great studio and (b) it's a stand-alone property. People can just drive up to the door and go in, and so we talked to everybody and everybody was way into it, and so okay we've all got to get tested. I guess the NBA bubble inspired me you know? Everybody got tested and they threw them all together and they were able to do

their thing for months. I just needed a few days. So we went upstate to a club I knew up there that was pretty large and comfortable and not open, and they let us use the place. We went up there for a couple of days and rehearsed. And then like everywhere, all I was trying to do was like out of the city, where people could just drive up to the place, not be on a subway, not be in a building or an elevator, nothing that would put anybody in potential harm's way. So we got upstate. And we rehearsed a little bit, and it was hard to tell the difference, because it was so relaxed. I mean nobody had anywhere to go you know, we had all the time in the world, nobody was bothering anybody, nobody had a teaching obligation, nobody had another gig. So I mean I wish it could have been longer but it was just a couple of days up there. And then I think we had planned to do one gig, because one place was opening up, but in the end we didn't do it. So we just rehearsed a little more and we went into Van Gelder's. And it was the same thing. No rush, nobody had to be anywhere, big studio, we were, like I said, we were all tested. So it was nice to have that time and that balanced the fact that okay maybe we were, all the passion was there, all the things that make those guys great was there. But maybe we were a little sloppier here and there. But we had time to like, okay, let's do it again you know. Sorry, go ahead.

MR: I understand the group came out of a Freddie Hubbard connection. But I wonder if at some point, did you feel not — intimidated isn't the right word. Was it a bit odd for you to be the head of a group where the majority of the players were anywhere from twenty to almost thirty years older than you? Now you had established yourself certainly as a presence in New York and had your due respect. But still, I'm wondering if any of this has been odd for you to sort of be in charge of musicians of that pedigree?

DW: Well there's many things I could say about that. I did work with Freddie Hubbard for eight years before — I guess they kind of overlapped a little bit. And the first night of the Cookers gig, or the first attempt at it, was something they asked me to put together because of my connection with Freddie. The guy wanted Freddie to come and like be the emcee, you know. The Night of the Cookers concert I don't remember the exact dates, but they are right around Freddie's birthday, and there was this club in Brooklyn where the guy's first concert when he was a kid was the Night of the Cookers concert. So he was always enamored with it. And every year he would try to do something, like try to get Freddie to come in. But Freddie lived in California. And he didn't have a very big club, so it was kind of a challenge to get Freddie to come in to blow out some birthday cake. And one year he finally said like, "I want to put together a Night of the Cookers reunion. I want Freddie to come but I want all the other guys there." So we got Pete La Roca and James Spaulding. We tried to get Harold Mabern but he wasn't available. Larry Ridley did it. And when Mabern couldn't do it we decided I could put together

some more Freddie Hubbard alumni. Ronnie Mathews did it and Kiane Zawadi did it. And that concert was a success. And Pete La Roca and James Spaulding were great. And that's what started it. It morphed into what the Cookers are today, but it started as this Night of the Cookers celebration, that people reached out to me because at the time I was working with Freddie, and, you know, they thought I can help get them to do something Freddie didn't really want to do which was come fly to New York to blow out a birthday cake. So as far — I don't consider myself the leader. That's one thing. I mean I try to get the gigs, I coordinate stuff, I'm on the trumpet. But in the rehearsal it's not like, "Look Billy, you're going to have to —" I mean there is maybe a little bit of a straw boss thing where I'm, like okay let's play this tune. Okay well that didn't really sound right, "Let's try that again." It's never like, "You really need to —" and those guys know it. I mean they'll mess with me sometimes. Billy Hart very early on was like, "Look man, we just don't do this for anybody." You know? I mean and their elders did that to them. This thing was always like look, this is a small club and we don't let just anybody — and you can't just walk in here and do this, you've got to bring something to the table. And I've always felt that pressure. You know I started on jazz late. So I always felt I was behind the curve. I always felt I was trying to catch up with everybody. And this in a way is putting me in a situation where I'm still doing that.

MR: I see. Have they ever talked about back in the earlier parts of their career I think critics and authors sometimes like to make an issue of race in jazz. And I'm wondering if you hear that from these musicians?

DW: I hear stuff about how they're treated. You know I don't think it's in jazz, I think it's in the world they live in. Like Billy Harper went to North Texas State and so did I. So one of our first conversations was like wow, North Texas State, it was a little different for a little Jewish boy from Queens. And then he told me his story and I'm like [holds up hands]. You know? "I couldn't live on campus. I had to live in a little shack on the other side of the tracks and I had to walk two miles to school and finally by the third year they let me live on campus but it was like a janitor's closet. You know they found a place for me because I had made the —" you know, like oh, whoa, okay. I get it. Somebody going like, "You're Jewish" wasn't exactly comparable. So I mean — the life, you know so the life, the life, I mean we're talking about our lives and stuff like that. Cecil McBee told me once when he was a little kid he just tried to make a couple of pennies shining shoes and a couple of cowboys came and picked him up and threw him in a trash can. You know? I mean there is so much stuff that informs who they are. It's not a barrage of that but when we're on a long train ride and people are talking about their lives, that's part of their life. I have nothing comparable you know. But I seem to be able to relate to their world philosophy in a lot of ways. I mean it's kind of like this knowing, seen it all, you know,

but have found a way to (a) sort of find the beauty in it, (b) you know, be very practical about things. I'll tend to get more caught up in little things because well I'll say I'm privileged maybe. I don't know. But it's never a thing, you know, they're very nice to me. You know I think you know in the end people are people. There are differences but I mean I think at this point I don't have to prove it to them but I think they know my heart's in the right place. You know? I put — and more importantly it's a musical thing. If it wasn't a good musical experience they wouldn't do it. You know? Or they would let me know. You know? They're not always on me but sometimes after a gig I can be walking off the stage after the last tune and Billy Hart can say like, "You took one chorus too many on that one, didn't you?" And I'm like, "Yeah, yeah I did." You know? The lessons are always there. Or the opposite you know. George Cables after a gig once I remember, "Man, you showed me something on that last —" so you know. So it's not a constant thing but it's you know I'm told.

MR: I'm fascinated by the connections between jazz and what's going on in society. Do you feel that those musicians that were young men in the 60s, do you have a sense that their music was significantly affected by the turbulence of the 60s?

DW: I think the old adage is — and I forgot it. Something about you can't play it unless you've lived it or something like that. Or you know if you have an experience it can't come out of your horn. I'm still floored by that sometimes. We can be just sitting at a rehearsal and getting warmed up and Billy Harper will take the horn out of his case and go like [woosh] and I can hear fifty years in the tone. I can hear that. I can't hear that with just anybody you know. So there's something, but it's more than that. I mean that is part of it you know, clearly turbulent times stir something up in you and it comes out in your music. But also, a lot of it is the level those guys functioned at, and the level of the people around them you know. I think I mean I'm generalizing but I think this goes to almost everybody I've dealt with from that era. They were always scared of somebody. There was somebody walking the earth — I mean Freddie Hubbard always told me about Lee Morgan. You know? And how determined — they all had a determination (a) maybe 'cause the stakes were higher I mean I can't speak to that stuff well but I mean if music like sports is a way out of something and everybody else around you is really good, you know if you're walking into New York and John Coltrane's there already what are you going to do? You know? And they did it. I mean I find that the level is much higher there because I mean that's why it was a smaller family, because not everybody can reach those levels and there were a lot of giants walking the earth then. [Inaudible]

MR: I want to read something from your website regarding the Cookers. It said the Cookers embody the serious-as-death commitment that it took to thrive on the New York scene some four decades ago.

DW: I like that. Did I say that?

MR: I was going to ask you. Well —

DW: I think maybe somebody put something I was trying to convey into better words than I could.

MR: Okay.

DW: Bless their little soul whoever they were. But I mean there was a lot of that. I mean at some point me and Freddie — Freddie Hubbard always wanted me to publish the charts I wrote of his music. I said that's a great idea, Freddie, and I'm happy to do that but do you know what would really make an impact and sell a lot of books and you know help the world is a Freddie Hubbard trumpet method book. And we sat down and we did a bunch of interviews. And at the end of it it was all a lot of fun and I learned a little bit. But at the end I was like I think I could write this book in one paragraph. You had a ton of natural talent and you tried harder than everybody else. You practiced harder, you were more dedicated and more determined than anybody else I ever knew. You know?

MR: Yeah.

DW: And what else? Try playing this. But that's the essence I got from it. And a lot of it was a competitive nature I think. And I mean I also got that from reading some Sonny Rollins stuff and discussions with Freddie about Sonny Rollins. Freddie got to New York — and this is the other thing I mean — sometimes when we're sitting somewhere waiting, the stories, I mean Billy Harper's story of trying to sit in with Elvin Jones is painful. Because they just didn't let anybody — you know you want to be part of this? You know? Go sit over there. Freddie Hubbard told me that, the first time he went to a jam session in the Bronx they were like, "Who are you? Go sit over there and wait." And at the end of the night, "Oh we forgot all about — come back tomorrow." "What are you doing here? Go sit over there." You know? And that kind of stuff drove him. I mean you know he was determined, and that's what I see I mean not only all the immense talent and all the immense work but a drive. Like nobody's going to tell me to sit over there again.

MR: You're making me think of a quote I have here, I want your reaction to it. This was from a recent discussion I had with a fairly well known jazz author and arts administrator. And he said this generation of jazz musicians has more technique, knows more theory and more history than any other, yet you almost can't tell them apart. I find it also odd that with these musicians, again more technically adept, theoretically sound than any other generation. We haven't had an overriding genius appear since John Coltrane, who died in 1967.

DW: Maybe there's a couple past Coltrane, and I'm sure if you open up a magazine today somebody's going to be called a genius. But I understand the sentiment of that. I don't know that I totally agree with it. I don't know how to put it exactly. I'm not sure they

have more technique. Maybe as a generalization, maybe from 1-50 they've all learned something, but I've definitely had rehearsals with guys out of school that really couldn't read the parts quickly, really couldn't, you know, they hit walls. I think they get to a certain level very quickly, especially younger guys. Younger guys get to a place very fast. But I think they hit a wall. And whatever is past that wall is what all those other guys did. I don't think the environment is right for that. I definitely have dealt with a lot of younger musicians who think they went to school and got an A and came to New York to make it and think they've arrived. I don't think it's even within their scope of what they think they have to do that there's that much more to do. Like you just got started, not you just finished your studies. So I think a lot of that I run into, but there's exceptions. I mean there are some, but it's going to be interesting to see how far they go. Some are great. And also another thing is I mean most are having longer careers than any of those guys ever did. I remember once I was doing something for Blue Note Records and we were discussing the young artist they had just signed and maybe put out their first record or second record and it wasn't really — they weren't stars — it wasn't really — they didn't blow up, it's not really happening for them. And I said, "Well maybe not everybody gets it by the time they're 23, 24. The irony is they'll probably let this guy make three records and by the time he makes his fourth record and figures things out you've dropped him." You know? So you know these guys are healthier and they have longer careers, but I mean it's — what's going on here basically, I don't like to distill things down to a basic thing but it might not be that off, you have guys that are going to school and learning a language, and learning that language well. Bebop is — that harmony, that's a challenge. But once you master that, then what? Or once you get to a certain point. Like you see the best guys who do that kind of thing essentially make the same record for twenty years. I mean there's a little growth, they're always going to get better, but, and I'm not saying this — I don't think this art form is limiting. But it seems like they've put it in a box kind of. Like ding-ding-a-ding, it's supposed to swing, it's supposed to feel good, but all the urgency of the 60s and those guys and the reason there is a certain urgency to it is because they were trying things new and they were changing things all the time. And now the guys got people studying that and kind of basically stopping at 1962 or something. And then you've got the guys that are trying to push things forward within that realm but there's not a ton of them. And then on the other side you have all the avante garde stuff. They don't have all that history. Some do, but they don't really have that. But they're trying stuff at least.

MR: I'm sorry, do they have the history of Ben Webster and before him?

DW: Well that's an interesting — that you chose Ben Webster — because I mean again, any time we talk this way we generalize and I'm going to get killed on something, but a lot of

the avante garde guys, as far as us, you know, swing, how we always analyze, I mean somebody analyzed it better than me and said, "Hey, they just skipped bebop." You know?

MR: Who skipped bebop?

DW: The more avante garde guys, have you seen, they're doing tributes to — you know Lester Bowie does Louis Armstrong. They come, I mean they skipped bebop. They took all the wonderful things about swing and that expressiveness and all the stuff those guys did, and they kind of continue on from there. That's where they found their more emotional truth or their melodic sense or whatever it is they're trying to do. I mean that's one school of avante garde and it is the ones that are like the amazing composers, the ones that really interest me personally from what I come out of, like the Henry Threadgills and the Muhal Richard Abrams is guys who at least wrote incredible music. You know when it comes time to soloing, you know, but those are the guys that are writing the most interesting music I'm hearing over my career, the last twenty, thirty years. Henry Threadgill, Muhal Richard Abrams, I'm trying to think of who else. There's got to be more than those. But that's growth I like. But those guys come out of another thing, and they also come out of a classical thing. I mean Henry Threadgill lives around the corner. I talk to him all the time. He's a Chicago guy. He talks about Gene Ammons all the time. You know? They know the music. So you're in this thing like okay, I'm trying to do something more based in this, more advanced harmony, hopefully swing based, whatever, in that realm. But I want the adventurous spirit of these guys. You know? To keep looking. That's what the Cookers I think grabs. Those guys came through everything, are well versed in everything and have always tried to push it a little forward. If you want it call it like the spiritual thing of the 70s or the more free thing of the 70s, or whatever. But whatever they've done is informed by George Cables with Dexter Gordon you know, Billy Harper with Max Roach. You know they came up through this stuff but it never was a limiting thing to them. You know, and Freddie Hubbard, that's what he told me all the time it was like, "Man we tried stuff all the time. We never stopped trying things." You know? I think sometimes better — those guys were so good they didn't miss as much so it wasn't apparent. You know? Or they missed better. I mean Billy Hart used to tell me some drummer used to tell him, "You recover better than anybody" and he didn't know how to really take that. You know?

MR: Yeah, left-handed I guess.

DW: But it's also true, I mean that's another thing about the Cookers, we've played together enough, we know when somebody's kind of going out on a limb a little bit, and they've got your back you know. They're not going to let you crash and burn unless they're mad at you or something. But that kind of trust goes a long way.

MR: When you look at the arts, music and the visual arts especially, sometimes I wonder if it gets harder to innovate? What do you do that's beyond Coltrane's "Ascension" or any number of examples of how the limits of the art was pushed? How do you go beyond that and still create something that people might accept?

DW: Well when you put it that way it sounds like a problem.

MR: Well you can put it in a different way. I'd be happy if you did.

DW: No, I'm half kidding, but half kind of acknowledging. I think what happens is I don't think anybody really tried to be an innovator. I think a lot of it was just natural growth. And the interesting thing is a friend I work with came back from Banff. I went to Banff right out of college. It's a jazz workshop in the Canadian Rockies. When I went there Dave Holland was running the program. So coming out of North Texas State kind of, I needed to listen up a little bit let's say, and that's actually where Muhal Richard Abrams was the guest conductor and we did a concert with him playing his music. But Dave Holland ran it. Dave Liebman and Richie Beirach were there, George Lewis, I don't know if you know him he was an avante garde trombone player. He was there. John Abercrombie was there. I'm trying to think of who else — Kenny Wheeler was there. Guys that were pretty much rooted in stuff but also trying to be — you know. I think it's just an approach and what happens happens. I think nobody can sit there and go like, "Well it's time to change music today." But it's definitely an approach. Again, you know, I go back to the Cookers 'cause there's just not many examples. Those guys are, I mean I'll recognize things they played from another time and I'm definitely guilty of it, but they're always pushing something. They're always trying something. It's just an approach, and the approach is the most important thing. You know? Never staying pat, just you know always pushing things. Everything seems fresh with them. You know there's no — I mean there might be a routine within it, I mean on this material we've definitely, I mean to put it in, it's not the right way to put it, it's actually the most wrong way I could put it, they've developed routines. I mean that's not the word I want to use when I'm talking about openness and freedom and stuff. But they've developed stuff within the tune but really what they're doing is using it as a launching pad to go somewhere. So I mean it was an interesting conversation I had with Billy Hart. We had done two records, Billy more than once was telling me like, "You know what? There are two very good records. I like these. I don't say that often but I like these two." And I called him up and said, "Hey we got offered to do a third record." And he said, "Why?" And I says like, "Well because we do this for a living? We keep making records." And what he meant was we found the material that we need to do what we do. Why do more? I said well you never know. We might find a couple more. And we definitely have, but the conversation went to okay why did Miles Davis and Wayne Shorter and Herbie, Ron

and Tony, why did they play "Autumn Leaves" every night when they were recording "ESP?" You know? Why was their set, I mean as far as the material they chose, basically the same every night for three — and over the three years they added a few things, but for the most part they were playing "Footprints" I mean they added some new tunes. They added "Footprints" and they added "Agitation" but they still played "'Round Midnight" and they had a set. And it was like why do you think those guys played those tunes all the time? And it was 'cause they knew that they could do anything on them. They were launching pads for them to do their thing you know. And you could listen to five Miles Davis' concerts in a row and those tunes are different every time. You know? What Herbie, Ron, and Tony did was never pat. It was challenging every night and they challenged each other every night and they did everything. I mean they're the penultimate rhythm section but that point is clear. I mean you know, you make new records for new material for fans. But you find the stuff to do live that is the launching point for you to continue to do what you do, or that gives you the openness to try that thing and you know the thing so if you miss you can get back on track. And we've continue that. I mean we do new records all the time and some of those tunes always make their way into the book. Some make their way into the book for a while and go away when something else comes along, but there's still three or four staples that we basically have done almost from the beginning, until something comes along that displaces it. And it's not like oh we're playing that tune again. It's like okay well what are we going to do with that tune tonight? You know? What's going to happen? You know. And there's no talk of let's do something innovative on that tune tonight. It's whatever grows out of our experience of playing together and doing this stuff and everybody knowing each other well enough to be like go ahead. So things can happen. And I've always tried to have bands that do that. And you know you miss more, you know you take more chances, but when it works I mean Miles missed. He missed bad. But it was the same with Herbie, Ron, and Tony, I can hear, now that I know the material I can hear when they missed things, but they're just so much better at it you can't really detect it. But I mean it's really all — I mean what I've found is it's really all about approach. I mean yeah, we're going to sit down and write a lot of great music, but how it's played on the bandstand it's really all about approach and the person's approach to the music. I mean I stick with those guys because they're great, but they also teach me that every night. And I'm the one who's maybe more locked into a certain thing by what I play but they'll push me towards that. Like you know I don't want to — say I play a certain tune and I like a certain phrases over it or something. I only seemingly play it when everything is not connect — it's like a fallback. Or it's something that gets started and then let's see where you take me today.

MR: Yeah.

DW: So a lot of it is approach. I wanted to say one thing about the innovation thing. So we were talking about Banff. Wow I got off on a tangent. So I went to Banff I don't know, right out of college, 1986, 1987. And 25 years later a friend of mine went and Vijay Iyer was the director of the thing. And what sounded like a very Kumbaya moment, I mean you know Banff is in the Canadian Rockies. It's gorgeous up there. So he had everybody sit outside and introduce themselves, all the students on the first day, introduce themselves and tell what your goals are. Maybe your goals for your career or your goals for the thing.

MR: The thing.

DW: And my friend told me one kid got up and said, "My name is so-and-so and I want to be an innovator." And I was like — and he laughed. He was telling me a joke. Like look at these kids, what the? And he's a kid, he'll grow up, he'll figure it out but it's interesting that some people think that's how it happens. Or people who are being considered in that realm play with that realm a little bit. You know. It's an interesting phenomenon. But I mean I'm going to look at it like let's say Stanley Kubrick. He's like one of the best filmmakers we ever had. Was he an innovator or did he just do — I think it was a quote of him, I think his quote was everything's been done, my job is just to do it better than everybody. You know? And that's — I'm going to keep perfecting my craft whether innovation happens or not it's not a goal, but I'm going to strive to be the best I can, whatever that means or however that manifests itself. Is somebody going to be an innovator? I don't know. Will I care? I mean somebody asked me about that a different way, not this way, this way is fun, and I said okay well let me ask you this, if people go to — if an audience goes to a concert tonight are they going to say like I really want to see some great music or are they going to say I want to see some innovation? You know? I mean I hope most people wipe that from their mind. I think certainly there are musicians who know how to manipulate the world they're living in. They're clever. They're smart people and they're good musicians and they know how to press buttons. I mean I know some guys who are just breaking in, working with a record label like they picked the perfect combination of tunes and musicians that make it pure catnip for the general press. Okay let's see, let's do an Andrew Hill tune. Let's do A Tribe Called Quest tune, let's you know just push every button. Now you've still got to do it well, but there's a clear path if you think you're one of those people that are considered in that way. It'd be like okay well let's continue to press those buttons. Hey! So and it works, but is it innovation? Is it even good? Is it even pure? I mean it's always good to have goals, it's always good if you're going to do a record or a project have a certain thing in your mind about how to go for this, and all the better if you succeed. But you know innovation is a tricky word. I mean I think in more straight ahead realms, more harmony-based swing-

based realms the changes are going to be more subtle and I don't think people will hear it. I mean a lot of things that are considered innovation these days are more, you're kind of hitting somebody over the head. The changes have to be bigger for people to recognize them. And I think in the realm of, I think Sonny Rollins spent fifty years perfecting his craft you know. Was he an innovator? I think so at the beginning, but he still kept going. You know? I think it manifests itself in different ways and more subtle ways. And the other thing, if you want to go into the world you're playing in nobody's looking for innovation in anything swing-based or harmony based. They put it in a box, it's been done already, and you know a lot of the music proves them right, but a lot of it doesn't. And you never hear about it.

MR: I love what you're saying about this. And it makes me think about rhythm sections and what they do with the time. And I'm wondering, in your opinion, in the Cookers, who's the main, who's in the driver's seat as far as the rhythm or is it a shared responsibility? And the reason I ask this is Cecil McBee said some very eloquent things about quarter notes, about playing the bass and approaching the quarter notes. And he said to the bassists, you are the timekeeper. You are the vibe of the entire group.

DW: That's true. I agree with that. I mean you know ask James Brown. I mean that comes, that's a fact in a lot of music. The drummer seemingly is the guy, because he's a little more easy to focus on him, plus with the fills and everything there's more going on with the drummer. But the drummer can't do that without the foundation from a bass player. And I have found, interestingly, and this is not, I mean you mentioned Cecil but this has got nothing to do with Cecil. What I have found over the years talking to various drummers is their taste in bass players is different than mine, or most people. Guys I think like Dwayne Burno is my guy. Like he's a little younger than me but I'm going to say my generation. He was in all the bands I did and their inception, my octet and my sextet, he was the guy. He was the guy who took the Ron Carter stuff and made it a language and did the stuff that Ron did, which is rare, guys who are to do substitutions and do all that stuff. I mean I could play records and I did this with many big band albums, Wayne Shorter material, and I could point to parts in the arrangement where Dwayne made it better on the fly. Because he knew where everything was coming from and he understood what you were trying to do and he knew how to take it somewhere. And I could point to it and like I owe him ten dollars for that, because I didn't write that, like in a soli section or something with the horns. He — it was like okay. I've even called him sometimes and I'd come to him and like, "Okay Dwayne, here you go. You own a piece of that." But that said, I was shocked when drummers, you know, drummers generations before me who came out of that music that influenced Dwayne, they didn't like playing with Dwayne. And he did, but some didn't, like no, no, get this guy. And that

guy was just [hand motion straight ahead] you know because they wanted that to play off that. If Dwayne is busy doing, you know, what are they doing. One of them even said that like, "What am I gonna do?" You know?

MR: They want to play with the time as opposed —

DW: They want the foundation and they want to be able to — even if they're not playing with the time per se or even the fills or whatever, they want the foundation for them to do their thing. And that's a big ask I think. But it's an interesting phenomenon because what Cecil's basically saying is even though I do all that other stuff, you know, I do this because this is what works in that situation. You know? But Cecil could be all over the place, but he can also just be [hand motion steady beats] if that's what the material calls for. You know? He does it. So that's, I mean, and that's another thing I love about those guys. I like these guys. Is they've all, and I've said this often, they've all been in the greatest bands that this music has shown. You know I used to — there was one tour where the record came out and we were on a good tour too and it was in June and there was like the basketball playoffs. And I kept using the San Antonio Spurs analogy because they were an older team but they were a team and they played well together. And I was like see — we're the Spurs. See they were all great players but they all know roles. They don't play the role all the time but they know how to make a great band. They've been a component in a great band. That doesn't just happen, you've got to — I don't want to say you've got to know your players, you know you have a role. You can still be the best musician you can be and play a role. It doesn't have to be a restricting thing and it makes the band the band. I mean Cecil knows that from Charles Lloyd with Jack DeJohnette and Keith Jarrett. You know Eddie Henderson and Billy Hart know that from Mwandishi with Herbie Hancock. They basically said look, Herbie just made everything sound right. But you know, so those were great bands. They were all like bought into the system I mean you know certainly there was I don't want to say "controversy" — you know there were some ruffled feathers here and there. But they all bought into the band. And you don't really see that mentality too much anymore you know. You see cliques maybe but I don't know if you see bands that much. I mean Jason Moran has kept his band together for a long time and it's admirable and it certainly paid off, those guys are great. And some guys, like young guys, like Immanuel Wilkins has just kept his band together for a couple of years now and he's starting to get out there and play. I don't think he'll be an interview but he's going to do some really interesting stuff. He's going to keep fresh. You know I'm going to go with fresh. I like fresh.

MR: Fresh, okay. Fresh is good. In your career, you've, it seems to be a constant balancing and juggling of tasks that you've learned you can do, and I wonder if some patron happened to drop in the scene and said, "I'm going to finance" let's say, "the Cookers for

a year. That's all I want you to do, this group is so important I'm going to finance the whole thing for a solid year." Do you think you would have trouble doing that and giving up all the other things that you do?

DW: Well I mean as I kind of said, the question has a different meaning now, interestingly. (a) like I said, the pandemic has kind of eliminated everything else. I mean I've been doing some things at home, I've known about some of this music before but I've discovered some things. There's an interesting period, I mean this is like the historical part of me which is fun, and this is the kind of thing where if things were normal I'd be like okay let me get this somewhere and try it. But apparently, I mean I sort of knew some of this, I know it better now. Apparently in 1967 Art Blakey hired Slide Hampton for the Messengers and to be the musical director. And Slide wrote a bunch of music, like sextet charts. And they're great. And they've never been officially recorded. You can see some bootlegs of it. There's a recording from RCA Studios, George Wein's birthday party where Art Blakey's band plays a set and they're in RCA Studios so they pressed "record" and it's just sitting there, nobody knows about it. But I got, in my capacity of other work I got to hear it and it's all Slide Hampton charts. And there's videos from 1968 and Slide's not even in the band, but they're playing all of Slide's material. And they're sextet charts and I'm enamored with sextet charts. I cut my teeth on learning how to write those Wayne Shorter sextet charts and all that stuff. And they're great. And I've been transcribing them and I'll do them eventually but that can wait a year to do this. I mean the timing is now. It feels like I'm almost just focusing on the Cookers now you know. Because when things are a little uncertain, things are not opening up, I mean honestly to give the David Weiss Sextet a gig now, when things are like you know you're not sure if people are coming out or whatever. I think I'm a tough sell right now. You know when things are more opened up and things are functioning normally and everybody has full schedules you know, but right now I'm focusing on the Cookers. And also I mean two years off — well it hasn't been two years off — a year off shows you anything you know nobody's a baby you know. I don't want to be like strike while the iron's hot but you know let's play while everybody is — yeah, I'll take it. And that can do it if there's an urgency, I don't know maybe I'm the one that's going to get hit by a bus and be the one. I wouldn't call it [inaudible] but there is a sense there that you know, hey, we're not going to do this for another ten years.

MR: Yeah. When I get asked to define hard bop it's hard. So do you have a definition of hard bop that I could borrow from you and I'll give you credit?

DW: Not a good one. Well here I'll put it — well that thing that was going on for a while was they asked Wayne Shorter what jazz is and Wayne said, "Jazz means I dare you." And I liked that because he's right. But when I hear "hard bop" to me, if somebody's telling me

I'm hard bop they're telling me to go fuck myself. You know? So it's not a good word for us. Hard bop to me is a way to pigeon hole the Cookers into 196- whatever. You know? Or me as a musician. I remember I did this band called Point of Departure. It's kids, it's guitars, I mean it's jazz material in it but it doesn't swing. It grows. I hope it grooves. It grooves, it's more my rock & roll childhood than anything else and when the kids, we finished a record the guys were like oh, who's going to — we're going to go play rock clubs? That's like I'll bet you right now that out of ten reviews of the record, nine of them will say "hard bop trumpeter David Weiss" or "hard bop material" or hard bop this. So yeah, hard bop means, you know, you're dead. You know? It should be an apt description of something but considering the mentality of the industry we're in they're basically saying we're not interested or you couldn't possibly hear anything innovative here. You know? We're not going to put this on NPR. It's, I mean I could be sensitive. I could be off base. But to me it's become a dismissive term for what we do now.

MR: I'm a little confused.

DW: Okay.

MR: Is bop — from a historical standpoint and from an art form — is hard bop less a respected genre?

DW: No. I wouldn't call it that. No. I don't think that's the issue. I think basically any — bebop, I think any of those forms that if anybody's trying to do them now, you know, you're playing a dead music where there's no possible room for innovation you know. There's nowhere to take it in a lot of people's lives and like I said, there's some truth to that. There's some truth to that, but if you do it and you're hopefully keeping it like a little more open ended and open minded and a little more free and you know have a spirit there and do all that stuff, they're not really talking about that. They just say like "hard bop." You know? So I find it a dismissive term just in my own personal frustration about how this music, when you put this music out here how it's addressed. And it's true. I mean this last record did a lot of good and I don't want to complain. I really don't want to complain, but the Cookers — up until this record — were never in the *New York Times*, were never on NPR, were never featured in any jazz publication. This *DownBeat* cover we just did is the first time we've been on a cover of a magazine, it's the first time there's even been a feature about the band in any of these magazines. We won the "*DownBeat* Critics Poll" as a rising star small group, and they did a little, they wrote a little blurb about it when we won. But not a feature. So I guess that's in a way saying some people acknowledge you're good but the way the jazz industry is and what we push and what we put out there is like what's going on today, you're dead.

MR: Is it partly a demographic thing too — if you put on the cover of *DownBeat* let's say everyone in the band is seasoned veterans. And the magazine is trying to get younger readership.

DW: Cool. Absolutely. You know I mean it wasn't this kind of conversation today but I remember within ten years I mean you know I talked to the guy at *DownBeat* before, the editor, Jason Koransky. And we were talking, I forgot what it was, we were joking about something but in that kind of realm you know. And he said the best selling magazine we had this year Ahmad Jamal was on the cover. So I don't know. And I think maybe *Jazz Times* tries to skew younger, maybe not. I mean yes there's this world out here and I'm not saying look at us we're giants, just talk about us. I'm just saying be inclusive. We're part of this. But be inclusive in all ways not just like European jazz festivals like, "Yeah we only want Robert Glasper" and that kind — we only want what the kids want — we only want what's current and hip and hot. And that's great too, but the ones that work for us are the ones that do that and do us. You know cause, again I don't want to get into the merits of the band per se but you know I'm happy with inclusion. Like give me the whole picture of jazz, like what's available out there now. Do I really want to hear a whole festival of just twenty-somethings and maybe one like a Joshua Redman. You know, so I mean it's a music industry and it's major labels involved now, it's just not a bunch of independent labels you know, it's not Blue Note and Prestige. These are corporations. So the pop mentality seeps into the jazz part of their — got us to mention his name. Yeah they want new, they want young, they want hot, they want to like pump them out and see if they take off you know and they run with it. I mean maybe the level of success is different than a pop artist, but you know I think it's great, the Robert Glaspers of the world or the Makaya McCraven or who else, Kamasi Washington. I think it's great that that stuff's out there but I mean it's just not the only stuff.

MR: Okay.

DW: And with Kamasi Washington you're like I mean here's the living embodiment of everything he's trying to do. If you listen to Kamasi Washington's first record and hear all those voices and stuff that's right off Billy Harper's first record. You know. It's Billy Harper, Pharaoh Sanders and a little of Coltrane. I mean you know be brought back 70s spiritual jazz to a new generation and more power to him for that, but at least be curious enough to check out Billy Harper. I mean Kamasi did it himself, he did a gig somewhere where he brought Pharaoh Sanders on the bill too, so I mean bless him. But that's what I'm just saying, there's a lot of music out there, there's a lot to go through, I've got to admit that. But you know inclusion. Nobody's dead. We used to talk about that with Freddie Hubbard you know, when we put a record out and everybody wanted to interview Freddie but all they wanted to do was talk about the 60s and Freddie would be

like hey I've got a new record out. You know? Or they want to talk about his chop problem or — hey, this is a positive day, I found a way to make a record anyway and I think it's pretty good and don't you want to talk about it? And after a while I said like, after a day of interviews he was like oh God. So I really think the mentality is isn't it great that this dead person is still alive to tell us about all this stuff.

MR: Wow. Well we've been at it for about an hour and it's very fascinating. I wanted to get one question in. If you had a tune, let's say you started it at the piano or something, and then you went for a walk and you start I don't know if you do this or not but maybe you're arranging it in your head thinking of the possibilities. What is the sweet spot for you as far as how many voices you have to work with?

DW: Wow. Good question. I'm going to say five. That's what I settled on. I mean I guess my patter about this has changed. There was a point where I could say look I never wrote a big band chart except for my final in college. You know? It never interested me in that way. I like small groups and I think the path I took and how — I settled on octet because, it was actually a Freddie Hubbard thing. Freddie was having his chop problems, he owed a record company a record. I was working with the producers and we were, you know, like ideas. I said well why don't we put a slightly larger ensemble around him? Buffer, you know, he was a great composer, buffer the material and make it sound more full and then he just has to pick his spots, you know, which became the whole reason we did the thing. So we did that record and that's the first time, and they threw me a couple of arrangements. I think Bob Belden did one or two and Bob Mintzer did a couple. And they threw me a couple. And that's the first time I think I wrote for that size band and I liked it. And it inspired me to put together that octet. That, plus that same production company was young lions time and a French company didn't have their finger on the pulse of what was going on in New York and paid us to make demos of all these young artists. And those guys, like gave it to me, because they didn't want to be bothered. So I produced them all and when I walked away it was like wow, these guys can write. There's nobody here, no innovators, there's nobody here that's like oh wow great solos. But the writing was great and that's what I combined. I told those kids like hey I'm going to put together an octet and we'll get together every week and just write. Write whatever you want, and that five was perfect. You can retain the small group thing. The material could have much more impact when you want it to have impact, you know, it just seemed like a nice — I mean I love sextet too and I guess the Cookers wound up to be somewhere in the middle because it needed to keep, to retain, when we originally did it it was Night of the Cookers. Night of the Cookers is two trumpets so we had to retain the two trumpets. And I think Night of the Cookers is two trumpets and alto and I wanted a little more — two trumpets and alto for an arranger, it's a little top heavy let's say.

MR: Yeah. Bright.

DW: It's bright but also I mean the one thing I always found with the Cookers or the Night of the Cookers and stuff like that is voicings. Because you know the tendency, what I do with the Cookers is I always put the — if I can, is put the alto between the two trumpets. Because otherwise, I don't know, you're veering towards Tijuana Brass.

MR: Yeah I was just thinking that.

DW: Yeah well it's a problem. And it's a problem to get around. So octet, I mean for this Wayne Shorter thing I did eight horns and I thought that was about as much as I'd ever need without having to change the mindset completely into a big band thing, which I think is a whole other thing. I wound up writing a couple of big band charts for another Wayne Shorter project that Wallace Roney was doing. And it wasn't — I guess one chart I actually had to arrange it, the others were just kind of re-orchestrating some things Wayne wrote. But I'm going to go with five. I really like that. I really like the five. But it is kind of arrangery. Three seems real natural and you can make three sound as full. I mean I'm still, all that Blue Note stuff and that Booker Little, Booker Little out front, all the Wayne Shorter records, all the Art Blakey sextet records, even Freddie Hubbard sextet records and this Slide Hampton writing for sextet I think it's my favorite stuff. I think it gives you the most flexibility and most, you know, you can really make things full if you know how to voice things for three horns.

MR: Great.

DW: But study Booker. Booker — the Slide Hampton stuff comes more out of that Booker Little school of type voicings. They're incredible. Hopefully one day they'll come out.

MR: I hope that you get to that and that it comes to fruition.

DW: Well it looks like I've got a year of a benefactor. You're going to hook that up, right?

MR: I'm going to work on it.

DW: We're talking Ivy League now?

MR: I started it, didn't I?

DW: No, we've had help from friends. During the pandemic people helped us get the record done. I have to say that.

MR: Excellent.

DW: Yeah I mean in a way we're going back to that, you know, oh what's the word for it — benefactor is not the word. What was the — what did Mozart have?

MR: He had a patron.

DW: Patron. That's what I'm looking — in a way we're going back to that, right? I mean you know —

MR: Yes, we need to.

DW: We may, whatever, you know.

MR: Well I'm going to go buy a few lottery tickets on the way home and you know.

DW: How many million do you have to win before you'd think about us?

MR: About seven.

DW: Okay. Fair enough. It can't be the first million, I understand.

MR: That's okay.

DW: We're not unreasonable.

MR: Okay. Well I am hoping you can come up here and cook. And this has been a fascinating conversation and I appreciate your time.

DW: Have you been talking to the other guys yet?

MR: Not yet but I will.

DW: They've got stuff too.

MR: I bet they have some stuff.

DW: It'd be great to come up there, if we can figure that out.

MR: Great.

DW: And it's a school, right? The students. It would be great for those guys to get together with the students.

MR: Indeed.

DW: They need, what do they call it, I just did a Billy Harper, we did a Billy Harper clinic like right before Covid, and it was like after a Cookers tour and I kept him out there to do a few other things, and I did some things for him. And I forgot, the director of the program, I told him yeah, I'm going to come along too. And he was like okay. What did I call it? A "generational translator." I had to help the kids understand what Billy Harper was telling them.

MR: Yes.

DW: In the context of what they knew.

MR: I know exactly what you're saying.

DW: I was joking a little bit but it's really true sometimes, it's really true. It's an interesting thing. These guys — never would these guys — they don't really see what they're saying, it's not as clear as they hope or something like that. So they need somebody who can relate to an iPhone or something like that.

MR: Right. Well thanks a lot for your time.

DW: Thank you.

MR: All right I'm going to sign off and then we'll say our good-byes.

DW: Okay. Take care.